PROJECT 01 · CONSUMER ORDERING

Ordering on DoorDash, through a human-factors lens

I ordered from the same restaurant on DoorDash and Uber Eats, audited each step against 10 cognitive concepts, sketched fixes by hand, and redrew them as before/after wireframes.

Scope

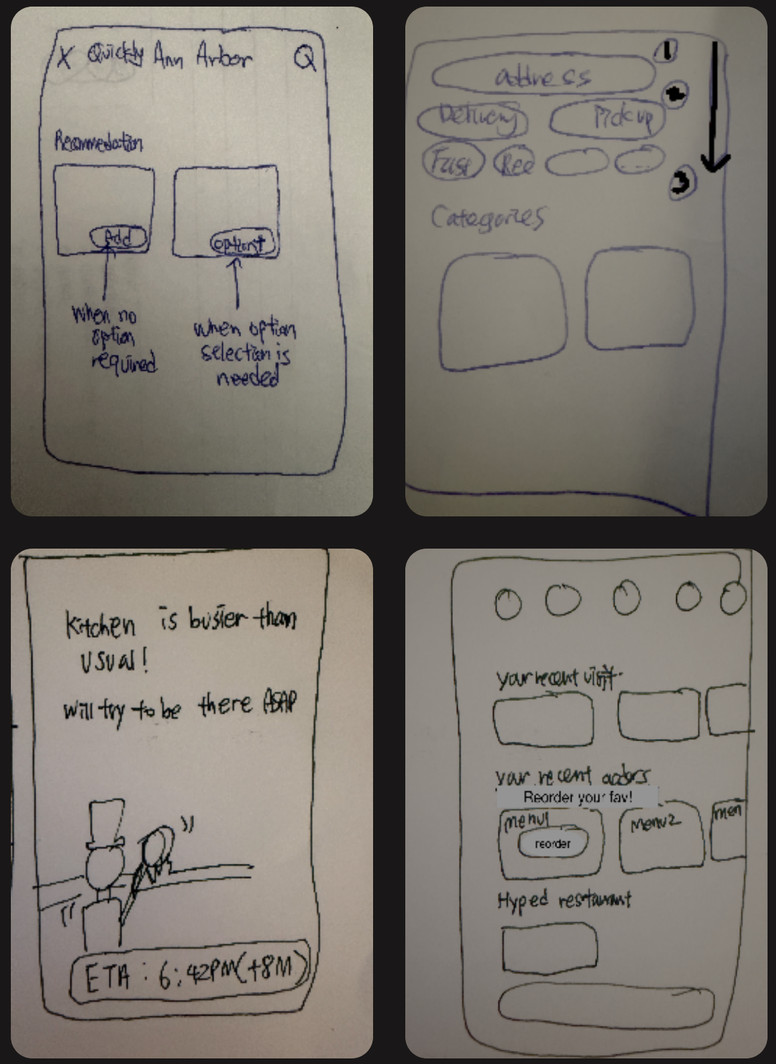
Menu, cart, tracking

Method

Comparative audit, sketching

Type

Concept work, not affiliated



01 · DOORDASH · WHERE IT BREAKS

Five friction points along one order

1 · HOME

Reorder means recall

Past orders are buried in a text list under the profile.

Recognition vs recall

2 · MODE

Pickup is hidden

Switching takes a drawer, a tab and a confirm.

SEEV: effort

3 · MENU

One “+”, two outcomes

Sometimes it adds; sometimes it opens options.

Gestalt similarity

4 · CART

No running total

The bar shows item count, not price.

Gulf of execution

5 · TRACKING

Silent delays

ETA slips with no reason given.

Situation awareness

Each fix follows one path: **the concept → what DoorDash does today → sketch → wireframe → user trade-off and commercial pitfall.**

01 · DOORDASH · CONCEPT 1 OF 5 · PERCEPTION

Gestalt similarity

Things that look the same should work the same.

THE CONCEPT

People group elements that share a shape, colour or icon style, and expect them to do the same job. When identical controls lead to different outcomes, the interface becomes unpredictable.

Johnson 2021; Norman 2013

WHY IT MATTERS WHEN ORDERING

Menus are browsed fast, thumb on screen. A surprise modal breaks the rhythm and makes people hesitate on the next tap.

IN DOORDASH TODAY

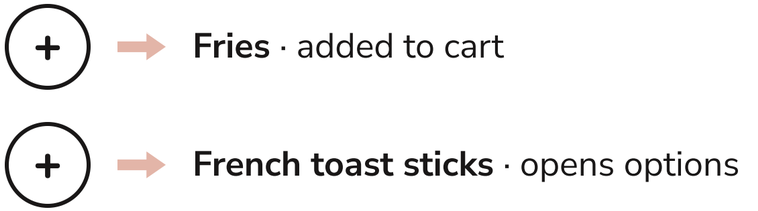
At one restaurant, the same “+” added regular fries straight to the cart but opened an options modal for French toast sticks.

WE READ LOOKS AS GROUPS



Two looks are read as two kinds of thing, before any label is read.

DOORDASH: ONE LOOK, TWO RESULTS



Same look, different result = surprise

01 · DOORDASH · MENU · GESTALT SIMILARITY

A button should tell you what it will do

CHANGE

Solid “+” for a direct add; an outlined “Options +” pill when a choice is required.

USER TRADE-OFF · INFORMATION SCENT

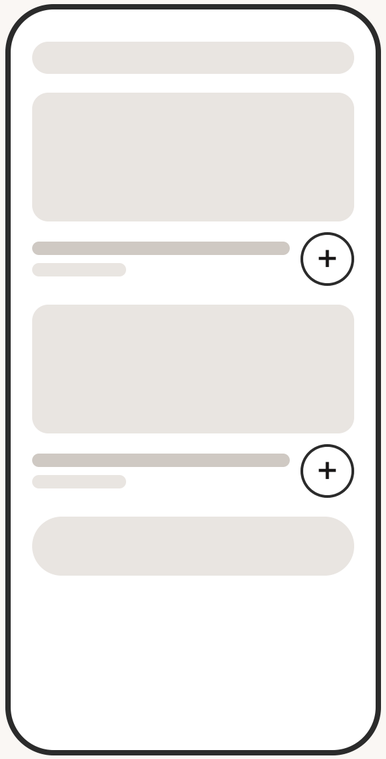
The wider pill can cut a dish description from 3 lines to 2.

COMMERCIAL PITFALL

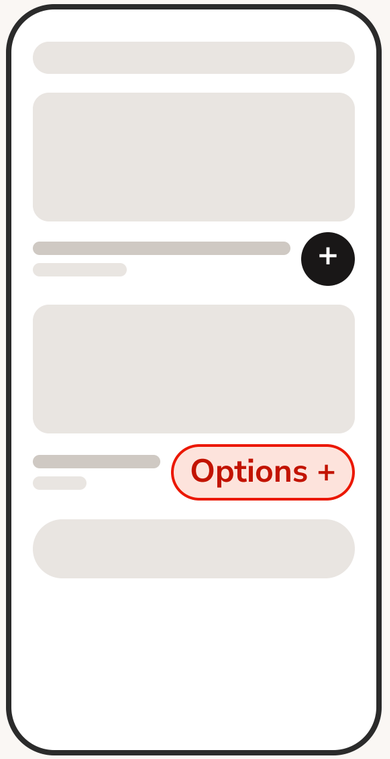
Why it may be deliberate. One quiet “+” keeps the photos in charge, and the modal is where size-ups and add-ons sell. “Options” can read as extra work.

Guardrail. Keep the upsell inside the modal; track add-to-cart for option items, not only fewer surprise modals.

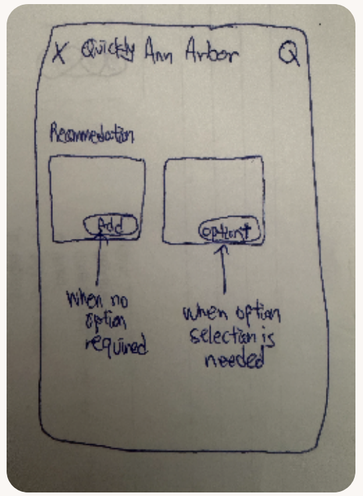
BEFORE



AFTER



MY SKETCH



Selective attention: the SEEV model

People look where it is easy, expected and worth it.

THE CONCEPT

Attention goes to what is Salient, Expected and Valuable, and away from what takes Effort. Salience and effort come from the screen; expectancy and value come from the person.

Wickens et al. 2014; Lee et al. 2017

WHY IT MATTERS WHEN ORDERING

If an option costs effort to reach, people stop checking it, even when it would save them money or time.

IN DOORDASH TODAY

Switching to Pickup takes four steps through a full-screen drawer. Uber Eats puts the same switch at the top of the feed: one tap.

SEEV MODEL

$$P(A) = S - E + Ex + V$$

Salience · **Effort** · Expectancy · Value. Effort is the one design can cut fastest.

SWITCH TO PICKUP TODAY · 4 STEPS

Address bar | Drawer | Pickup tab | Confirm

REDESIGN · 1 STEP

Delivery | Pickup

01 · DOORDASH · HOME · SEEV ATTENTION

Pickup in one tap, not four

CHANGE

A “Delivery | Pickup” toggle right under the address. One tap switches mode and filters stores.

USER TRADE-OFF · INFORMATION SCENT

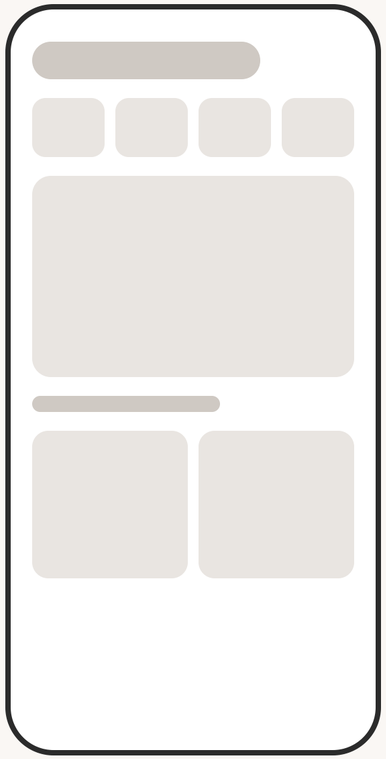
The bar pushes the first deals below the fold.

COMMERCIAL PITFALL

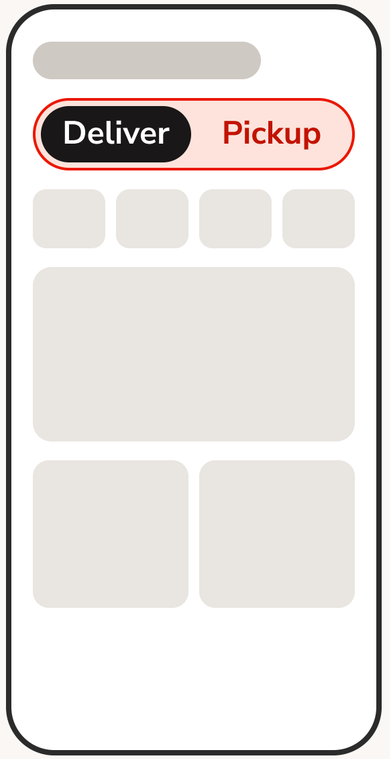
Why it may be deliberate. Pickup earns no delivery fee and a smaller cut per order, so a hidden switch protects delivery revenue.

Guardrail. Before rollout, measure whether pickup orders are new (won from rivals or the restaurant’s own app) or just cannibalised deliveries.

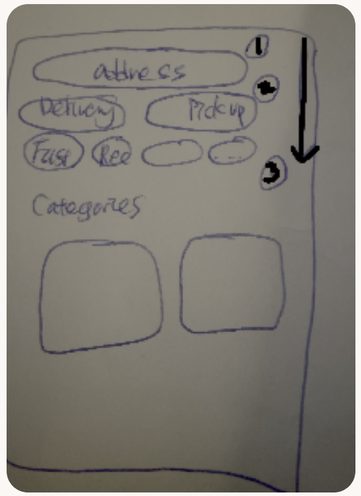
BEFORE



AFTER



MY SKETCH



Recognition over recall

Seeing is easier than remembering.

THE CONCEPT

Recognition means identifying something when a cue is in front of you; recall means retrieving it from memory with no cue. Recognition takes far less effort.

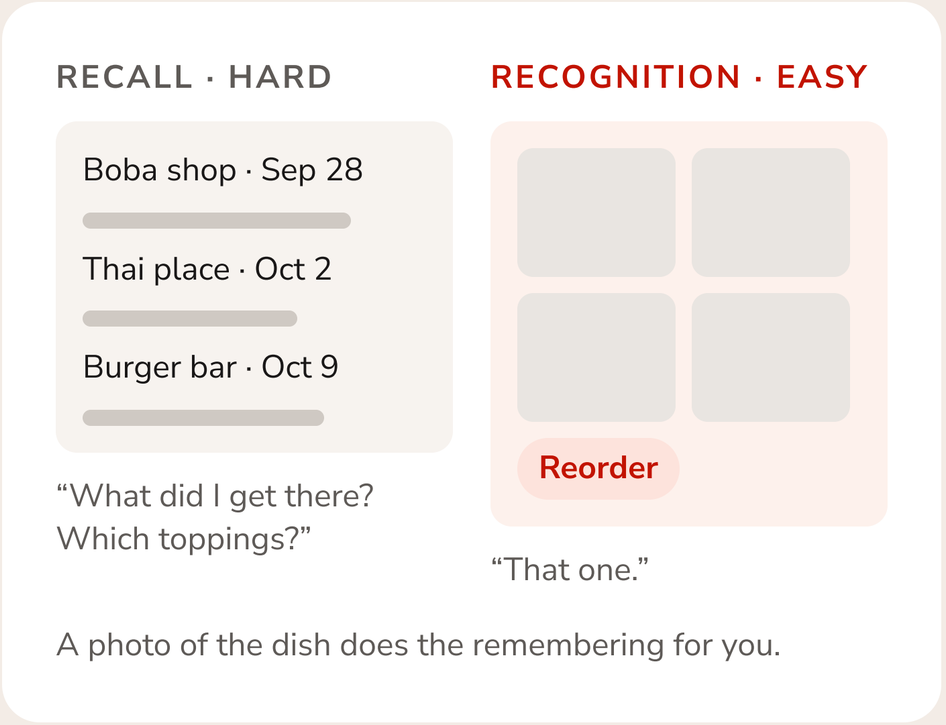
Norman 2013; Johnson 2021

WHY IT MATTERS WHEN ORDERING

Many food orders are repeats. The faster a past meal is recognised, the shorter the path from opening the app to checkout.

IN DOORDASH TODAY

Past orders sit behind Profile → Orders, as a text list of restaurants. The dish and the options you chose have to be remembered.



01 · DOORDASH · HOME · RECOGNITION VS RECALL

Reorder the dish, not just the restaurant

CHANGE

A “Reorder your favourites” row of dish photos, with your options saved and a one-tap Reorder.

USER TRADE-OFF · FAMILIAR VS NEW PATHS

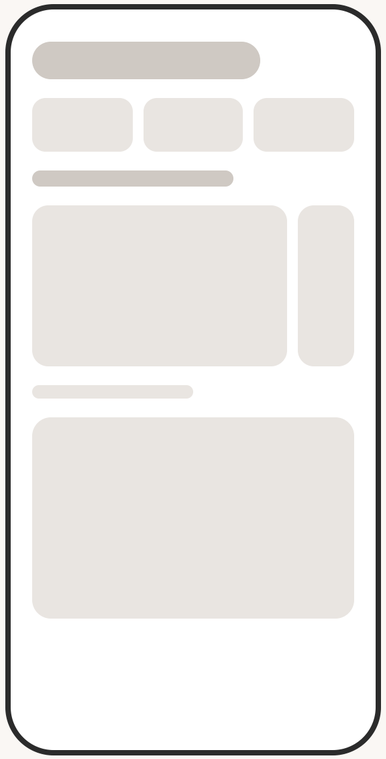
Faster repeats, but less discovery of new merchants.

COMMERCIAL PITFALL

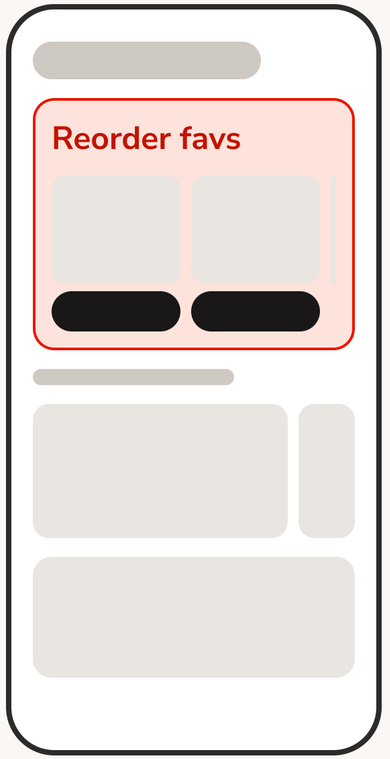
Why it may be deliberate. The top of the home feed is prime space for new stores and sponsored listings. A repeat row there sells less discovery.

Guardrail. Show it only to people with a repeat pattern, at their usual mealtimes, below the first sponsored slot.

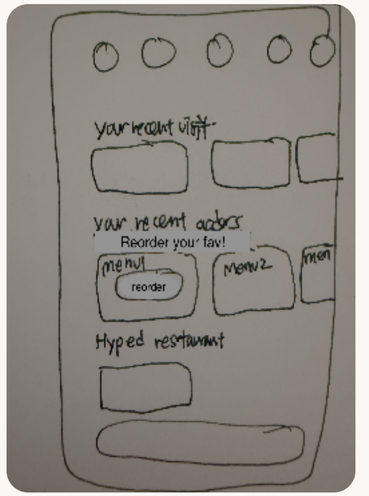
BEFORE



AFTER



MY SKETCH



Situation awareness

Not just where my food is, but when it will really arrive.

THE CONCEPT

Three levels: Perception (seeing the cues), Comprehension (understanding what they mean) and Projection (predicting what happens next).

Endsley 1995; Lee et al. 2017

WHY IT MATTERS WHEN ORDERING

Waiting for food is planning: when to leave a meeting, when to set the table. People need level 3, and level 3 needs level 2.

IN DOORDASH TODAY

The live map and countdown work well. But when the Dasher had reached the store and the food wasn’t ready, only the ETA moved, with no reason, even after I paid for faster delivery.

THREE LEVELS, DURING A DELAY

Level 1 · Perception — OK

Live map: the Dasher is at the store

Level 2 · Comprehension — MISSING

Why is it late? Kitchen, Dasher, traffic?

Level 3 · Projection — SILENT

The ETA moves, with no reason given

Without level 2, people can’t trust level 3.

01 · DOORDASH · TRACKING · SITUATION AWARENESS

When the order is late, say why and say when

CHANGE

A banner: “Kitchen is busier than usual (+8 min). Revised arrival 6:42 PM.” Merchants share a prep estimate.

USER TRADE-OFF · EXPECTANCY

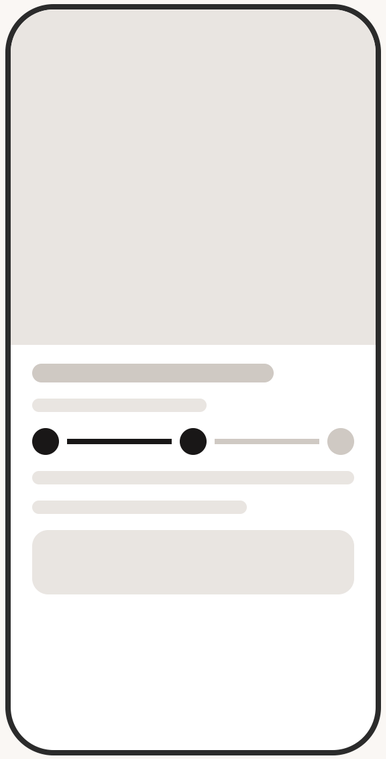
Repeated updates can erode trust in the ETA itself.

COMMERCIAL PITFALL

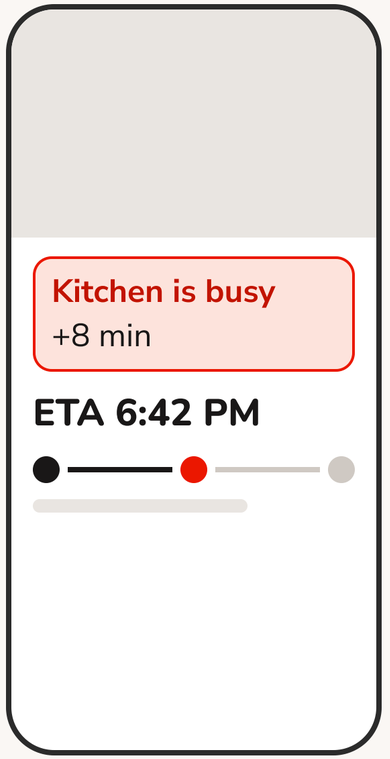
Why it may be deliberate. Naming a cause can blame a merchant partner, and an honest “+8 min” can trigger cancellations and refund requests.

Guardrail. Neutral wording, shown only past a delay threshold; track cancellations and support contacts against today.

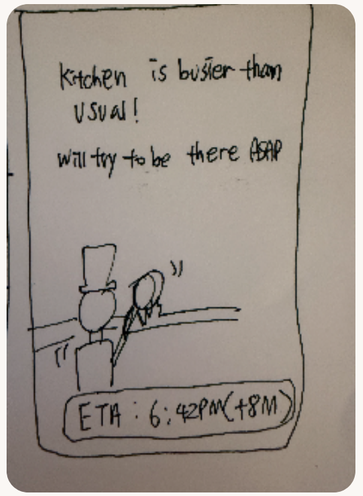
BEFORE



AFTER



MY SKETCH



Gulfs of execution and evaluation

Every tap should answer “what just happened?”

THE CONCEPT

Execution is the gap between a goal and the actions it takes (“How do I do this?”). Evaluation is the gap between a system change and understanding it (“What happened?”).

Norman 2013

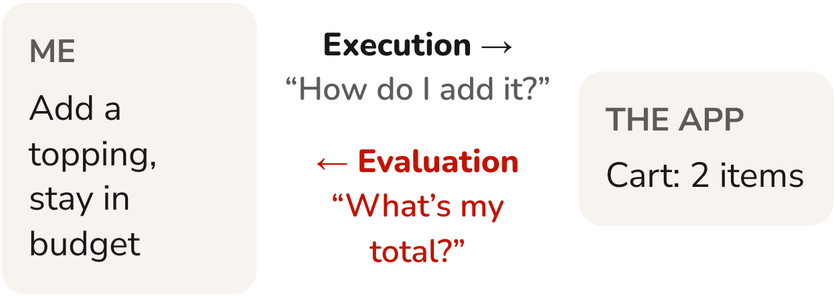
WHY IT MATTERS WHEN ORDERING

In a cart, the question behind every tap is “what am I spending?” If the screen doesn’t answer, people answer it at checkout, sometimes by leaving.

IN DOORDASH TODAY

The cart bar shows the item count and “Add $10.20 to get $6 off”, but never the current total.

NORMAN’S TWO GULFS



A $2 topping goes in. The bar still says **“2 items”**. The answer comes back only at checkout.

The gulf of evaluation stays open

01 · DOORDASH · CART · GULFS OF EXECUTION & EVALUATION

Show the running total before people tap

CHANGE

A full-width sticky bar, “2 items · $18.50”, that updates the moment an option is added.

USER BONUS · FITTS’S LAW

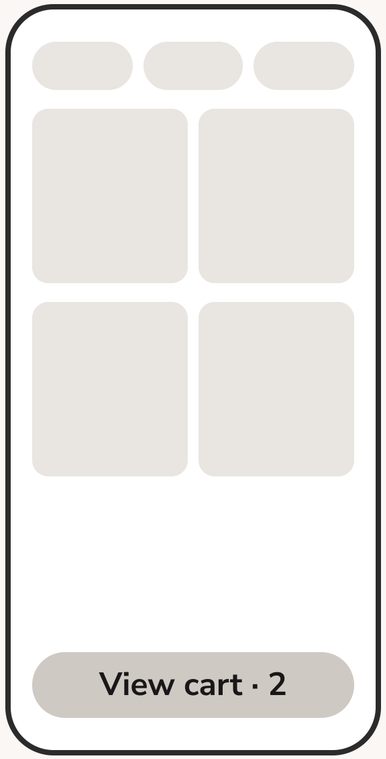
A full-width target at the thumb’s edge is fast to hit.

COMMERCIAL PITFALL

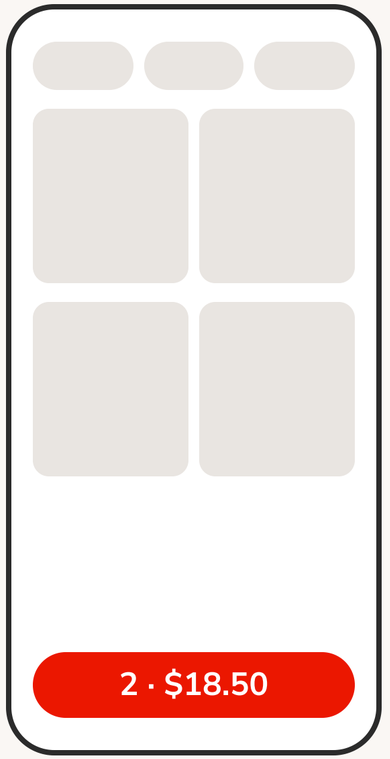
Why it may be deliberate. Hiding the running total keeps attention on food, not cost, and “Add $10.20 to get $6 off” grows the basket. A live total can make people trim it.

Guardrail. Pair the total with the deal, “$18.50 · $1.50 to $6 off”, so transparency still sells the upsell. Track basket size and checkout drop-off.

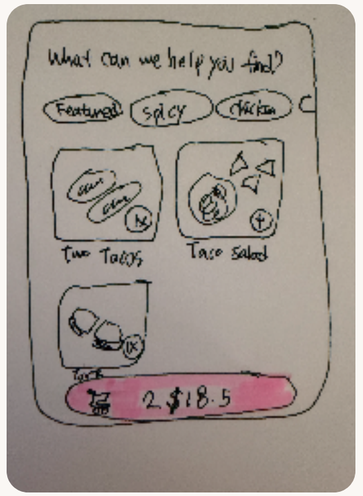
BEFORE



AFTER



MY SKETCH



01 · DOORDASH · USERS AND THE BUSINESS

Each fix is weighed for the user and for the business

Change	Concept	User trade-off	Commercial pitfall	Metric to test
Options + pill	Gestalt similarity	Shorter descriptions	Fewer opens of add-on items	Surprise modals, option-item adds
Delivery | Pickup	SEEV: effort	Deals below the fold	Lower fee per order	Pickup share, new vs cannibalised orders
Reorder favourites	Recognition vs recall	Less discovery	Less space for new and sponsored stores	Time to checkout, new-store orders
Delay banner	Situation awareness	Trust in the ETA	Cancellations, merchant blame	Cancellations, support contacts
Running total	Gulfs of evaluation	None (Fitts's Law helps)	Smaller baskets	Basket size, checkout drop-off

Next step: a clickable prototype of the five changes, then a quick test with five frequent DoorDash users.